

GLITCH — Diagnostic Sprint

A 3-week embedded residency to diagnose where the real bottleneck lives before anyone writes code.

F o r e c a s t · R e s i d e n c i e s · 3 w e e k s e m b e d d e d

Every module runs three tracks at once.

NARRATIVE

*You stopped building the wrong thing.
The three weeks of diagnosis saved
six months of shipping.*

COGNITIVE

*Diagnosis > prototype > production.
Every symptom is mapped to a root
before any solution is drawn.*

IDENTITY

*From feature-shipper to root-cause
diagnostician.*

Why this matters

Establish shared understanding of what the org is protecting.

"What is this org afraid the diagnosis will find?"

01. Stakeholder Fears

150 min

Interview 5 stakeholders for their fear.

Prompt: One 30-min interview each. Only question: 'What are you afraid we'll find?'

Debrief: Cluster fears. Publish the fear map.

02. The No-Blame Contract

45 min

Set the diagnostic frame.

Prompt: Draft and co-sign a 1-page no-blame diagnostic contract.

Debrief: Read aloud in the kickoff. Post to Slack.

03. Success Definition

60 min

Define success for the sprint.

Prompt: Facilitated session: 'A successful diagnosis is one that ____.'

Debrief: Convert to 5 measurable success criteria.

The reframe

Show that symptoms are almost never the problem.

"Which symptom has been hiding the actual problem?"

01. Symptom Wall

240 min

Post every complaint as a symptom.

Prompt: One week of Slack, tickets, meeting notes.
Every complaint → sticky note.

Debrief: Cluster. Ask: 'Which cluster surprises you?'

02. Root Trace

90 min

Trace 3 symptoms to root.

Prompt: Pick 3 symptoms. Ask 'why' 5 times each.

Debrief: Present to leadership. Note their reaction.

03. The False-Problem List

30 min

Name the problems that aren't problems.

Prompt: List 3 things everyone treats as problems that aren't.

Debrief: Circulate to leadership. Ask for pushback.

Organize complexity

Introduce the diagnostic framework: 5-season × 5-state grid.

"In which season and which state does this org break?"

01. The Grid Score

180 min

Score the org on the 25-cell grid.

Prompt: For each cell: 1-5 score with 1-line evidence.

Debrief: Present to leadership as diagnostic.

02. Missing Cell Interview

240 min

Interview the cell with lowest score.

Prompt: Book 3 more interviews around that cell.

Debrief: Ask: 'What does this cell need to become a 3?'

03. The Diagnostic Report

480 min

Write a 5-page diagnostic.

Prompt: One page per season. State score per cell.
Root cause per season.

Debrief: Circulate. Get one leader signature per season.

Pattern discovery

Present findings and let the org argue with them.

"What did we get wrong in our diagnosis?"

01. The Findings Read-Out

90 min

Live present findings to leadership.

Prompt: 90-min read-out. 30 min findings, 60 min pushback.

Debrief: Log every pushback verbatim.

02. Pushback Integration

240 min

Rewrite the diagnostic based on pushback.

Prompt: Integrate top 5 pushbacks. Publish v2.

Debrief: Ask: 'Which pushback changed the diagnosis?'

03. The Public Wall

60 min

Post the diagnostic where anyone can see.

Prompt: Print. Post in the largest common space.

Debrief: Note who stops to read. Talk to them.

Commitment

Recommend one — and only one — thing.

"What is the smallest thing that would unblock everything else?"

01. The One Recommendation

90 min

One page. One recommendation.

Prompt: One page: recommendation, rationale, cost, undo condition.

Debrief: Present to leadership. No slides.

02. The Bet Contract

45 min

Formalize the bet.

Prompt: Sign a 1-page bet: recommendation → success metric → 90-day check.

Debrief: Post the bet to the team.

03. Handoff to Prototype

90 min

Prepare the prototype residency brief.

Prompt: Draft the 1-page brief for the next residency.

Debrief: Handoff meeting with the next team.

How the arc unfolds.

01	Week 1 — Landing 40h	Love	No-blame contract signed.
02	Week 1-2 — Symptom map 30h	Magic	Symptom wall + roots.
03	Week 2 — Grid score 20h	Calm	5-page diagnostic v1.
04	Week 3 — Read-out 20h	Open	Public v2 diagnostic.
05	Week 3 — Bet 10h	Free	One-page bet signed.

COMMITMENT CONTRACT

"What one thing will this org bet on based on this diagnostic?"

Based on this diagnostic, _____ will bet on _____ by _____. The success metric is _____.
The undo condition is _____.

Witness — One member of the executive team.